

THE IMP

Written by

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The Imp | Confidential For Submission Only | Stone Zhong

EXT. Front of the street of Scotland Yard - morning London 1835

Bright morning sunshine falls over the street, an unexpected visitor arrives.

A prisoner carriage creeps slowly toward the gate of Scotland Yard.

Inspector George

Hold up, right here!

Set him down gently.

Be careful, Gentleman.

I won't answer for any trouble.

[Long shot, camera pushes forward slowly]

The carriage door opens, a sixty-year-old nobleman steps off the carriage.

He wears a red-black waistcoat over a white ruffled shirt, but his hair is matted and greasy, his fine formal clothes crumpled and dirty.

He looks nothing like a real noble, but like a thief who stole aristocratic garments.

[CUT TO Medium shot from behind]

The man's back takes up three-quarters of the frame, blank space is left at the upper right of the picture.

(His feet land on flagstone ground, every step sluggish)

Once he fully gets down from the carriage, the head and shoulder

of George Freya Stewart emerge in the blank upper-right space.
He stands stock-still, staring blankly toward the precinct gate.

Inspector George

Lord Peverill, it has been a good while since we last met.

We've crossed paths but once since your uncle's passing.

.....

Ok, my Lord, come with me this way

The inspector walks in front, the nobleman follows unhurriedly behind.

Dagyns (V.O.)

How many times have you yearned to utter what lies hidden deep within your heart?

You long to let it all burst forth, even knowing the act is wrong.

In the consideration of the faculties and impulses – of the prima mobilia of the human soul, the phrenologists have failed to make room for a propensity which, although obviously existing as a radical, primitive, irreducible sentiment, has been equally overlooked by all the moralists who have preceded them.

Humans, a strange sort of creature, tend to do things beyond all expectation.

But can established doctrines explain the confusion behind these deeds?

Is it the devil's doing, or human nature?

The devil?

Merely an excuse for mankind to shun the truth.

"Perversity" is only part of it.

INT. Underground Cells beneath Scotland Yard - dark and damp

The nobleman follows the inspector into a single cell under Scotland Yard.

It is a world totally different from the sunny outdoors.

After the man sits down, the inspector looks at him.

Inspector George

My Lord.

Even if you knew my father, I will follow the British Imperial Judicial System and handle matters strictly in accordance with law.

Now, I'm going to call our chief clerk, Mr. Gregory.

Wait here.

He'll arrive at once.

The man says nothing, only hangs his head and stares at the table.

Inspector George

(Stepping away from the cell, he murmurs under his breath.)

What a freak.....

Water keeps dripping from the ceiling into a wooden bucket.

Tick-tock dripping fills the quiet cell until a door creaks open

and breaks the silence.

The nobleman's bowed face faces straight to the lens, sunlight filters through the window and covers half of his face.

Footsteps draw closer and closer, a voice comes from off-screen.

Gregory Bennett

Greeting, my lord.

I am Gregory, the chief clerk here.

You may address me as Mr. Gregory.

I've heard a few things from Inspector George.

(Glances at him gently)

How are you feeling now?

The man stays silent.

Gregory Bennett

(Voice softens, hesitant)

Very well.

Shall we talk about something else?

Your estate, and your uncle... Er.....

I heard you were taken in by him after your mother passed away..

Lord

Dagyns....

Gregory Bennett

Sorry, what?

Lord

You have not asked for my name.

I am the Earl Peverill Third.

Dagyns Peverill.

Mr. Gregory.

Gregory Bennett

Apology, my lord.

Would you talk me through what happened, my lord?

Dakins

Which one?

Gregory Bennett

.....Just all we need to know about this case.

Dagyns suddenly bursts into laughter.

Dagyns

I want to tell everything, which part do you want to know?

Gregory Bennett

.....

The clerk falls quiet, staring at Dagyns in surprise.

Dagyns

Mr. Gregory, I want to ask you a question.

Is there anything you've done that you've never spoken of?

Gregory Bennett

What do you mean?

Dagyns

(He lifts his head slowly, gazing toward the clerk, and daylight filtering through the outer windows slowly fades away.)

Say it, I will say mine.

I shall speak of mine first, then you may share yours.

Let us talk openly.

Is that clear?

Gregory Bennett

(Voice stern and unyielding)

This is far from a casual chat in a garden.

It is I who conduct this inquiry, Mr...!

Dagyns lowers his head and smirks, seemingly mocking the clerk; his loud laughter cuts Gregory's words short.

Gregory Bennett

(Says nothing, staring at Dagyns in terror.)

.....

Dagyns

See?

You clearly have hidden thoughts.

You called me Lord just now, now you switch to Mr.?

Perversity!

Gregory Bennett

I will called the George, you weird person!!!

Dagyns

Easy, my friend.

(A faint, calm smile tugs at his lips)

Did you not wish to hear my story? Stay and listen.

There is no harm in it.

Gregory Bennett

(He says nothing, sitting quietly and listening to Dagyns.)

Dagyns

Ok, where to say.....

CUT TO - MANY YEARS AGO in County of Norfolk -

EXT. Outside Peverill Manor - A light drizzle drifts over the road/ Year 1785(Now, Dagyns is 10 years old)

TWO ELDERLY LADIES OF HIGH SOCIETY (Maggie/Eleanor)

(They hold umbrellas, walk slowly in fine rain and watch young
Dagyns)

Maggie

Poor boy, his mother died far too young.

He's left alone to live with his uncle.

Eleanor

(Trembles slightly, voice lowered)

Haven't you heard, Maggie?

They say it was the devil.

Maggie

Devil?

Eleanor

People claim a devil took his mother's life.

Maggie

What about the boy?

Could he be possessed by a devil?

Eleanor

What a strange thought.

Does this child look possessed to you?

Look at him.

Maggie

(Startles slightly)

He's looking right at us.

The two umbrella-holding ladies walk up beside Dagyns.

Maggie

Boy, we are Maggie and Eleanor, your neighbors.

Come to us if you ever need help.

Your uncle has done so much for us.

Eleanor says nothing, only watches young Dagyns softly.

The gate opens, his uncle walks out from inside.

Alistair Peverill

Dagyns, come in, something I had to tell you.

Oh, a nice day to you two lovely ladies, Lady Margaret and Lady Eleanor.

I need to talk with Dakins privately, so I can't entertain you today.

My apologies.

The two noblewomen smile and nod.

Eleanor

We've chatted with Dakins just now.

We told him he can turn to us for help anytime.

Alistair Peverill

It's very kind of you both.

I thank you on Dakins' behalf, dear ladies.

Dagyns, come.

Little Dagyns follows his uncle into the house.

INT.Great Hall of Peverill Manor - Beside the sofa.

Sandalwood scent fills the hall, the space carries both fairytale warmth and royal mansion grandeur.

Young Dagyns sits on the sofa, Uncle Alistair Peverill kneels on one knee to talk to him.

Alistair

Dagyns, I'm terribly sorry about your mother's passing.

But, you still have your uncle.

Me.

From today on, we'll live together.

Let go of the past and stop dwelling on it.

Ok?

The boy stays silent, staring blankly at his uncle.

Alistair

From today onward, you shall bear the surname Peverill.

Upon my passing, you will inherit my title and become the Second Lord Peverill.

At home you may call me Uncle, but out in public you must address me as Lord or Earl Peverill.....

Try not to fixate on your parents for now.

You'll learn everything gradually as you grow up.

Alistair pulls the little boy into a tight hug, pats his back and whispers in a faint voice.

Alistair

Oh...boy.

EXT. In the carriage (On their way to the banquet, Dakins and his uncle travel by carriage.) - evening 1795

Alistair reads a newspaper inside the carriage.

Alistair

War, War, all about is war

Their English civility has vanished entirely.

Madness.

It is as if they have let loose all their long-suppressed grievances.

Dagyns

(Look out the window, voice tight)

They keep committing wrong deeds even fully knowing they're sinful.

Such is human nature.....

Alistair

Dagyns?

Dagyns

Uncle, are we nearly there?

Alistair

Oh, it seems they've fully prepared the banquet even amid wartime.

The carriage pulls up outside the banquet hall gate.

A footman bows deeply and holds out a hand.

Lobby Boy

This way, my lord.

Alistair

Attlaus, would you escort the coachman to the carriage yard?

I'll take Dagyns inside.

It's his first time here, and he's a little shy.

Attlaus

My pleasure.

Alistair

By the by, has the Duke of Stewart arrived today?

Attlaus

He's already inside.

Alistair

Come Dagyns.

INT. BANQUET HALL - EVENING

The whole hall glows under newly developed gas lamps.

Alistair walks across the hall to Duke Stewart's spot.

Alistair

Stewie!

Duke of Stewart

Fancy you're still around after all these years!

The two men embrace.

Alistair

Oh, Stewie, You've not laid eyes on me in years, so you never guessed I've got an heir now, have you?

This is Dagyns, my nephew

Dagyns, this is Duke of George, ranked below the Crown and above all baronets and knights.

There something you have to learn from him.

Dagyns looks at Duke Stewart with eyes that see through worldly vanity, then gives a deep traditional aristocratic bow.

Dagyns

Greeting, lord Stewart.

Duke of Stewart

Greeting, Dagyns.

You've raised an admirable heir, Ali, by the looks of him.

Good boy, now I have something to talk with your uncle, would you step aside for but a moment?

Just a moment, sorry.

Uncle and Duke turn their heads together, facing away from Dagyns.

Alistair sips red wine and lowers his voice.

Alistair

(low voice)

What matter cannot be spoken in the kid's presence?

Stewart

Ali, it is not a matter of the boy.

The talk concerns none other than yourself.

Alistair

Me?

Alistair glances around to check for onlookers.

Stewart

Do you remember that thing three years ago.

Alistair

George, do not quibble over words.

Our acquaintance stretches back ages, no need to beat around the bush.

Just say.

Stewart

Ok, it's Paston.

He borrowed money from you to build charities across London.

Remember?

Alistair

What of it?

It brings him joy to help others, and pleasure to me as well.

Stewart

You really forgot, you really forgot.

You tell him never to mention the money was borrowed from Earl Peverell, and deny any acquaintance with the Earl entirely.

You say it, remember?

Alistair

Of, course, what's the problem, what hat has put you in such a distrustful mood this day?

Stewart

My dear Alistair, the strange thing is, shortly before you arrived, he suddenly said among guests that he knew Peverill.

Right after that he went on to say...

(Stewart falls silent for a moment, his gaze drifts toward Paston by the dessert buffet.)

Stewart

Never mind.

He's right over there, the long-haired man staring down at the pastry counter.

Go ask him yourself; he's full of things dying to spill out.

Duke Stewart and Alistair walk toward Paston, Dagyns follows right behind.

CUT TO - In the banquet hall before Dagyns and his uncle arrived Amid crowded guests, Duke Stewart chats with nobles, Baron Paston walks over to greet him, yet the Duke is called away by a noble lady.

NOBLE GUESTS

Greeting Paston.

Paston

Greeting.

NOBLE GUESTS

He looks worn out from constant requests, doesn't he?

Everyone's trying to corner him for a word...

Never mind, Paston.

Would you join our discussion?

We're debating the fate of war orphans, closely linked to your charity foundation.

Come and listen.

Paston

My pleasure William.

William

Don't stand on ceremony, Paston.

Come on over.

Baron Paston walks toward the dessert table.

Chatter drifts over from the table.

Viscount Kentis

Paston and William!

Come over here, we're in the middle of a heated discussion.

Most surrounding talk centers on ongoing wars, until a random

comment drifts into Paston's ear.

NOBLE GUESTS

I think the Earl Peverill will handle this, his standing carries enough weight to make Duke George set aside his pride.

Viscount Kentis

Watch your tongue, lad

Do you even know him?

Barely any of us are acquainted with him.

NOBLE GUESTS

I.....

Viscount Kentis

Well, Paston and Wiilliam, what do you think of this.

Does either of you happen to know Earl Peverill as well?

William

Well, actually....

William falls into conversation with Viscount Kentis, Paston holds his wine cup and listens with an unchanged calm face.

But a whisper rings inside his head.

Paston (V.O.) (QUIET, WHISPERED THOUGHT)

You know the Earl Peverill, why hide it from them?

He funded your charity foundation.

Say it....Say......

Outwardly Paston's expression stays normal as he listens to William, but his inner mind struggles: one side wants silence, the other pushes him to confess.

A pulsing heart appears on screen, then a hand grabs it

(Annotation: purely artistic effect, no real devil exists).

Unable to restrain himself, Paston shouts out loud.

Paston

I know the Earl Peverill!

He lends the money to me, or I would never build my charity foundation.

His voice echoes across the hall;

Duke Stewart stops chatting with ladies and looks toward him.

William hurries forward and grabs Paston's arm.

William

You alright? I'll have my wife make headache medicine and send it to your shop later.

Paston ignores William and turns to Kentis.

Paston

Yes, I knew him, he is my friend.

He taught me a lot, so I believe he will keep his word.

He whips his head sharply toward William (Annotation: shot styled after Toshiro Mifune's iconic turn).

William loosens his grip gradually, staring in shock as Duke Stewart approaches.

Stewart

All right, everyone, disperse.

The banquet's atmosphere relies on your attendance elsewhere.

Guests leave the spot.

Stewart

Have some pastries to calm down, lad.

Paston

I'm sorry, Your Grace.

I couldn't hold back my urge to speak, and countless more words remain unspoken inside me.

Horse hooves clomp outside, candlelight catches Peverill's passing carriage through the window.

Stewart

Anything left unsaid can be told directly to Lord Peverill—he's just arrived.

Paston hangs his head and sighs, Duke Stewart heads for the gate to welcome Alistair.

CUT TO - THE TIME ALISTAIR AND GEORGE FACE PASTON

Stewart

So, it's all the matter wat I want to tell you

Alistair holds a pipe in mouth and stares at Paston.

Alistair

I thought I impressed upon you repeatedly to keep this matter private.

Have you fallen upon some straits of late?

Paston

My Lord, I could no longer hold the words back.

I'm not insane.

Just that urge.....

I cannot understand why words spill out against my will.

Kentis walks past, seemingly holding unspoken thoughts and watching their group.

Alistair

Have you something you wish to say, Lord Kentis?

Kentis

No, your grace, I.....

I've just spoken with Lord Paston

All is fine.

Kentis leaves with wine glass in hand.

Dagyns stands aside watching, everything unfolds exactly as he predicted.

Duke Stewart leans close to Alistair's ear and whispers.

Stewart

(Voice tight)

I warned you long ago excessive kindness is unwise in this world.

Alistair

(muttering under breath)

Huh.....

I.....

Before Alistair finishes, banquet host Marquis Masel invites all guests into the main hall.

INT. main banquet hall

Marquis Masel stands in the hall's center.

Masel

My noble guests, welcome to tonight's feast.

It is my great honour to host all of you here.

May this feast bring us joy and friendship.

We have a distinguished honoured guest with us tonight.

Please join me in welcoming our distinguished visitor, Earl Peverill!

(The crowd breaks into applause.)

He's standing right there.

Now, Ladies and gentlemen, let us enjoy elegant dances performed by young artists invited from London's Royal Academy.

All guests turn toward Alistair;

pipe in mouth, he waves to acknowledge applause.

After Masel finishes speaking, Dagyns ponders briefly then speaks to his uncle.

Dagyns

Wasn't he the man who blocked your bank expansion plans back then, my lord?

Why would he invite you to his banquet?

It's.....

Alistair

Dagyns, people are not always what you take them for.

They must keep certain unutterable thoughts locked away in their hearts, for speaking aloud would land them in trouble.

Not every soul chooses to live that way.

Dagyns

Can resist?

Alistair

They must hold their resist regardless..

Remember, Dagyns: it is basic noble etiquette.

Dagyns

Yet at heart, are we not still human?

Human instinct is not so easily restrained.

Alistair

Dagyns, what's wrong with you today?

Dagyns

Nothing much.

I just saw Paston's demeanor and wonder how he could blurt everything out so casually.

He seems to have more left unsaid.....

Alistair

Don't talk that anymore, Dagyns!

You must hold your resist.

Forgot what I've taught you?

Dagyns

But uncle, I just can't hold.

I want to say.

Alistair

I beg your pardon?

What did you just call me?

Seems someone's forgotten everything they've learned.

You little....

Just as Alistair flies into anger, Duke Stewart cuts in.

Stewart

Ali, I'd like to take Dagyns around to meet other guests.

That'll leave you in peace—what do you say?

Alistair falls silent, pipe in mouth watching stage shows.

Duke George leads Dagyns down from viewing stand; his eyes hold curiosity mixed with faint resentment.

INT. In the Peverill Manor, Dagyns' Bedchamber - evening 1805 (Now, Dagyns is already 30)

Dagyns sits at desk writing his diary.

Dagyns (V.O.)

I still can't figure out why Paston said those things.

I've been trying to work out whether it was raw human instinct or the work of evil.

As for that guy who passed away.

Kentis.

I believe he has it too, only he holds it in completely.

Hardly anyone else could possess such iron self-control.

And I truly admire him for that.

But out of regard for my uncle, I hardly get to speak of this at home.

By the way, thinking of him, I always brings to mind his rigid doctrines.

If only I could get my hands on his fortune...

No, no, why am I having such thoughts?

If I.....

But, what if it was just an accident...

A knock sounds as housemaid Meria walks in.

Meria

Pardon the interruption, Master Dagyns.

Lord Peverill requests your presence in his study to fetch his usual book and a candle.

Dagyns's gaze drifts thoughtfully to the candle on his desk.

(V.O.)

Dagyns

I suppose I ought to have seen this coming...

Dagyns

Very well, I'm on my way.

You may take your rest now, Meria.

Meria

Thank you, Master Dagyns.

Should you need anything else later, do not hesitate to send for me.

Dagyns follows Meria out of his room.

INT. Alistair 's Bedchamber

Dagyns

Shall all candles be lit for you, Uncle?

Alistair

No, just the two by the bedside.

Thank you, Dagyns.

Dagyns

Uncle, may I ask a question?

When did you pick up the habit of reading in bed?

Alistair

Oh..., you say this.

When I was young, your mother and I were just the same.

Whenever Father—your grandfather—sent us off to bed, we'd race to finish the final page of our books.

Looking back now, it makes for a lovely memory.

It was then I picked up the habit of reading in bed each night before sleep.

Dagyns

Have you kept this habit all these years?

Alistair

Sure....

Dagyns, is something amiss?

Why the sudden question?

Have you at last found yourself charmed by reading?

Dagyns

I've always thought reading is a wonderful thing.

Alistair smiles.

Alistair

That is splendid news indeed.

Dagyns

I shan't keep you up any longer.

Good night, Uncle.

Alistair

Good night, my boy.

Dagyns exits the room, screen cuts to black then switches to next morning.

CUT TO THE ALISTAIR 'S BEDCHAMBER - MORNING

The frame centers on Alistair's bed, bedroom door on left.

Meria pushes door open with breakfast tray.

Meria

It's time for breakfast, my Lord.

Lord?

No reply, faint footsteps approach outside.

Meria

Lord, my lord, God.

Right as footsteps reach doorway, Alistair wakes abruptly.

Alistair

What's wrong, Meria?

You look utterly terrified.

Meria

My lord, you gave me quite a fright.

I thought you...

Oh, breakfast is ready if you'd like some.

Alistair

Rest easy, Meria, my time has not yet come.

Oh, Dagyns, will you join me for breakfast?

Dagyns steps slowly in and picks up bedside candles.

Alistair

No thank you, Uncle.

I've already eaten.

Let me take these candles away for you.

Meria

Master Dagyns rose early to write.

You need not worry over him.

Dagyns

Uncle, I'm heading to the market to pick up some supplies.

Enjoy your breakfast at your leisure.

Alistair

What a good kid, isn't he?

Though his disregard for certain noble etiquette does give me constant headaches.

Wouldn't you agree, Meria?

Meria

Don't say that, my lord.

Master Dagyns is an excellent young man at heart.

Alistair chuckles.

Camera zooms on Dagyns's hand squeezing candle tight, wax nearly crushed.

Alistair

By the way, Dagyns

(Uncle calls his name a second time.)

Dagyns?

Dagyns

What is your bidding, Uncle?

Alistair

Have you sent for the carriage?

Dagyns

Of course.

Alistair

Right, return at your earliest convenience.

Dagyns

Sure.

CUT TO THE DUSK - INT. THE DINING HALL AT PEVERILL MANOR

Alistair sits at table while Meria arranges tableware.

Alistair

Why has Dagyns not returned yet?

Meria

Fear not, my lord.

The market is crowded today, errands shall take a while longer.

Main gate opens, Dagyns enters followed by servant carrying two sacks of goods.

Alistair

Well, Dagyns, it seems you've had a fruitful day.

We're about to dine and have been waiting only for you.

Dagyns

Coming straight away, Uncle.

These two sacks hold provisions for Meria.

I've only purchased two books.

I shall put them away and join you shortly.

Servants carry goods toward kitchen.

Meria

Thank you most kindly, Master Dagyns.

INT. In the Dagyns' Bedchamber

Dagyns takes an item hidden inside his newly bought books and tucks it into left desk drawer.

Alistair's sudden shout echoes.

Alistair

Dagyns!

Dagyns visibly jumps from shock.

Dagyns

I shall attend you instantly, Uncle.

INT. FRONT THE DINING TABLE AT PEVERILL MANOR

Alistair laughs uncontrollably at Meria's joke.

Alistair

HAHAHAHA... Dagyns, you must hear this—it's utterly hilarious!

You're a clever one, Meria.

Dagyns

What's got you laughing so, Uncle?

Alistair

A lamb spitted on a lance becomes a lancer!

HAHAHA.....

Meria laughs alongside him.

Dagyns

Then I take it mutton's for supper.

I can already catch its aroma.

Alistair

Capital!

Meria, bring forth the supper.

Meria

Yes, my Lord.

Alistair turns smiling to Dagyns.

Alistair

Then, Dagyns, might you tell me what volumes you purchased today?

Dagyns

Sure, uncle.

I've purchased *The Monk* and *The Last Man*.

Both are works of remarkably advanced thought.

I read a portion aboard the carriage, and find them splendidly written.

Civilisation, I fancy, advances precisely as these great authors foretell.

Alistair's face darkens instantly.

Alistair

Nonsense all of it!

Rubbish!

You ought to study Shakespeare and classical histories to polish your gentleman's breeding, rather than clutter your mind with absurd, morbid fantasies!

Dagyns

Yet Uncle, such works grow far too rigid and stale.

I doubt they stir fresh thought within the mind.

Mankind's progress must never stand still.

I...

Alistair

Enough of this argument!

Set aside the debate.

Let us dine.

Meria serves Alistair first then Dagyns.

After two bites, Dagyns cannot contain anger, drops cutlery and storms back to bedroom.

Meria

Master.....

Alistair

Leave him be.

Let him remain in his chambers to reflect on his conduct.

How else shall he grow into a proper gentleman.

CUT TO THE EVENING - IN THE DAGYNS' BEDCHAMBER

Dagyns writes diary when Meria knocks.

Meria

(Knock, knock)

Master, may I come in.

Dagyns

Please.

Meria

Here is your dessert.

Lord Peverill would like a private word with you, though he is about to retire for the evening.

Dagyns

Well.

I shall carry his candles and books over shortly; you may retire now

Meria curtsies gracefully and leaves.

Once maid leaves, Dagyns adds new lines to diary.

Dagyns (V.O.)

I think....

I think the inner urge gnawing at me can no longer be held back.

He pulls open drawer; camera slowly pans from Kant's *Religion within the Boundaries of Mere Reason* on desk to the poison-coated candle hidden inside drawer.

Scene fades out, shifts to Alistair's bedroom.

INT. In the Alistair's bedchamber

Dagyns carefully lights two bedside candles, igniting the poisoned one while glancing briefly at his uncle absorbed reading Shakespeare's King Lear.

Alistair

Thank you, Dagyns, for coming each night to light my candles.

Dagyns

I shall not trouble you further, Uncle. Rest well.

I take my leave.

Dagyns walks to door, half body outside when Alistair calls out.

Alistair

Dagyns, wait for a moment

Had we the chance to turn back time, could you find it in your

heart to pardon my rigid, foolish ways?

Dagyns

I have never borne you any grievance, Uncle; forgiveness is therefore unnecessary.

Rest well for the night.

After closing door, Dagyns mutters low.

Dagyns

(mutter)

You repeat the same mistake: err first and repent afterward.

It is far too late for remorse, old man.

Next early morning

Frame centers on Alistair's bed, Meria pushes door in with breakfast tray.

Meria

My lord, time for breakfast.

My lord, my lord.....

You've been sleeping so heavily lately.

Did you stay up too late reading?

She shakes Alistair with no response, puts tray on side table, leans ear to his chest to check breath.

She staggers backward in fright, knocks table over, crockery smashes to ground.

Camera cuts to staircase landing, Meria's scream echoes across entire manor....

Close-up shot of wax dripping down the fatal bedside candle.

INT. ALISTAIR'S BEDCHAMBER - DAY (Shortly after Meria's discovery.)

Household doctor, head butler and parish priest have all arrived.

Dagyns stands aside staring at his uncle's King Lear, doctor speaks to him.

Doctor

My lord, is natural death.

Dagyns stays silent, head bowed over book with sorrowful look.

Priest speaks next.

THE CLERGYMAN

(soft, somber tone, glancing toward the late lord's bed)

The Lord's will be done.

He has slipped away peacefully in his own chambers, spared lingering pain and earthly affliction.

I shall enter his passing into the parish burial register at once, and hold prayers for his soul this evening.

The funeral rites may be arranged three days hence, as is our custom for landed gentry.

After priest finishes, Meria collapses to ground weeping hard.

Footsteps ring at doorway, head butler announces.

Head Butler

(raising voice from doorway)

His Grace, the Duke Stewart!

Duke Stewart enters holding testament document to read aloud,
young George follows behind.

Duke Stewart

By the late Earl's final testamentary instruction and established
peerage succession law, all titles and landed estates devolve
entirely to his sole lawful heir, Dagyns.

From this hour forth, he succeeds as the Third Earl Peverill,
Lord Dagyns.

All servants kneel in unison.

HEAD BUTLER & SERVANTS

(in chorus)

My Lord!

Dagyns

Please rise, all of you.

My uncle's passing weighs heavy on every soul beneath this roof,
mine most of all.

I shall uphold his legacy, tend to this estate and see each of
your duties fairly kept in the days ahead.

Servants stand to prepare funeral, Dagyns walks out corridor with

Duke Stewart.

INT. CORRIDOR OUTSIDE ALISTAIR'S BEDCHAMBER - DAY

Duke Stewart speaks sorrowfully to Dagyns.

Stewart

(to Dagyns, tone grave and sincere)

I am truly sorry for your loss, Dagyns.

Your uncle laboured faithfully all his days, rare for a peer of his station, he never turned away common folk in need.

He was an exceptional man, and let us honour his memory here today.

Dagyns

(voice low, still gripped by grief, clutching his book lightly)

Thank you, Your Grace.

His kindness was the quiet mark of who he was.

I shall strive to follow his example and carry on his good works for the estate and its people.

Duke's gaze falls on King Lear in Dagyns's hand.

Stewart

He never outgrew his fondness for Shakespeare, did he?

Dagyns

Shakespeare is my uncle's favorite.

In his eyes, no other writer could ever hold a candle to

Shakespeare.

None came near him.

Stewart

(chuckles faintly, warm reminiscence in voice)

Old friend...

Oh, forgot a thing.

Let me introduce my son, George Freya Stewart – my heir, the only boy among my three children, who turned eighteen only recently.

Dagyns locks sight with George.

Dagyns

Greeting.

George

Greeting, your Grace.

George executes formal noble bow.

Duke continues speaking.

Stewart

I know full well where my son stands with his noble breeding.

He still has much left to learn.

Dagyns

Your Grace, you're too modest to belittle yourself.

Duke laughs then launches into long speech on traditional noble theories.

Dagyns listens seemingly carefully yet lower lip trembles as unspoken words struggle out, until he cuts in.

Dagyns

No, I don't think so.

We must abandon rigid ancient aristocratic customs and look ahead.

Stagnation shall doom our class entirely.

Each generation of nobility ought to forge its own principles; we cannot cling blindly to outdated customs of the past.

Dagyns grows more impassioned while talking.

Duke Stewart

Excuse me?

George breaks into talk abruptly.

George

I cannot agree.

Britain's aristocracy has prospered all these years precisely thanks to the steady framework laid down by our forebears.

It is those long-standing rules that built our solid foundation, rather than...

Dagyns

Hold your tongue, boy.

This is no place for your input!

Dagyns's eyes fly wide then he covers mouth staring down floor in shock.

Dagyns

.....

Stewart

(fixes George with a stern stare and chides him sharply but restrainedly)

George....

(turns back to Dagyns, easing his stern expression into a weary, apologetic tone)

My apologies, Lord Peverill.

George has behaved improperly.

Given how heavily your uncle's passing weighs on you, I think you ought to rest for the day.

We shall take our leave now.

George follows father slowly downstairs, repeatedly glancing back at Dagyns confusedly, while Dagyns stays rooted staring floor in shock...

CUT TO THE 30 YEARS LATE - IN THE PEVERILL HOUSE, 1835

INT. In the Dagyns's bedchamber - DAY

Now over sixty years old, Dagyns still keeps writing diary every

day, bright morning sunlight falls across his face from window.

Dagyns (V.O.)

Britain today reeks of foul fumes, factory smokestacks rising everywhere across the land.

Aristocratic mindsets have undeniably shifted, yet has human civilisation truly advanced?

Or have men merely indulged in deeds they once dared not commit, all bursting forth at last?

To my mind, the latter is far more probable.

As for myself, having inherited my earldom, I have watched those around me pass away one after another these past few years.

First came the Duke of Stewart; word of his death reached me three or four days late, likely his household had severed all ties with my own.

Then poor Meria.

She sank into perpetual melancholy following her uncle's passing and perished in the end.

Physicians attributed her death to overwhelming grief, though I hold it stemmed from years of erratic living habits—there is no such ailment as sorrow suffocating a soul.

I shall spare recounting the fates of the rest.....

Dagyns stops writing halfway, words stuck on tongue.

Dagyns (V.O.)

Speaking of my uncle, I must needs speak of...

No, best leave this matter for another day.

No, I cannot contain myself any longer...

Yet I must hold my peace.

I have to, above all else.

It was my uncle's precept.

I must not...

After finishing disjointed diary lines, Dagyns stands up, feeling unwell and constantly tugging collar downwards.

He leaves uncapped fountain pen on desk and hurries out bedroom; camera closes up on pen against blurred background...

Dagyns rushes through hallway and down stairs, runs into butler Edwin.

Edwin

Good morning, my lord.

Are you intending to head out at this hour?

.....

You appear unwell.

Dagyns

Aye, I am bound out presently.

You remark I look poorly; it is only this stuffy chamber, paired with this wretched weather.

I mean to step outdoors for fresh air and purchase a dip pen.

Should Viscount Thomas call, inform him I am away on business.

You say I look poorly only from stuffy room air and terrible weather.

I mean to step outdoors for fresh air and buy a dip pen.

If Viscount Thomas calls, tell him I'm out for business.

Edwin

As your wish, my lord.

Dagyns

Edwin, I have told you before—spare all the formal courtesies whilst we are within these walls, speak plain and at your ease.

Edwin

But my lord, such formality has long grown into habit, and I scarce can break it.

Dagyns

Alright.

Right before walking out gate, he turns back with unfinished words.

Dagyns

By the bye, Edwin, how fares your mother?

Has her condition improved after the medicine she had last time?

Edwin

Ah, my dear lord, I am most grateful for your kindness.

She can now stroll among the neighbours and chat freely.

Without your aid, she might well have...

She has even sent some cured sausages from our hometown as a gift for you, my lord.

I shall have the kitchen prepare them for your supper this evening.

Dagyns

Indeed?

Please give her my sincere thanks.

Now I'm off. Keep a good eye on the house for me, Edwin.

Edwin

I shall do all in my power, my lord.

Send for your carriage at once, my lord.

Dagyns walks out.

EXT. Nodd's Pens & Stationery - noon

Carriage pulls up outside pen shop, Dagyns climbs down with coachman's help, shop owner's daughter comes out to greet.

Beatrice

Welcome, my honoured Lord Peverill.

Dagyns

You are...?

Beatrice

I'm Beatrice, my lord.

Dagyns

Beatrice....

What a lovely name.

By the way, where's Mr. Nodde

Have the pens I ordered been finished?

Beatrice

(She stands up and calls toward back room.)

Father! Lord Peverill has come!

Dagyns

Is Master Nodde your father?

I never knew he had such a lovely daughter.

Beatrice

Thank you kindly, my lord.

Shop bell jingles, Nodde pushes door out.

Nodde

Forgive my daughter for any discourtesy, my lord.

Here are your pens, my lord.

Crafted from the finest materials available on the market, each bears your personal crest and name.

Dagyns

Much obliged to you, Nodde.

I'm off for lunch now, I'll commission another set some other day.

Nodde

It has been my honour, my lord.

I'll wait for your next order.

Dagyns boards carriage and departs.

CUT TO THE ANGEL INN - CLOSE TO THE AFTERNOON

EXT. FRONT OF THE ANGEL INN

Dagyns finishes meal at inn gate and speaks to coachman.

Dagyns

Edmund, I'm heading for the market.

Wait here for me.

It's but a short stroll away on foot.

Edmund

As your wishes, my lord.

EXT. Marketplace

Dagyns picks fruits at fruit stall.

The shopkeeper

My lord, we have fresh fruits shipped all the way from Australia.

Would you like to check them out?

Dagyns

Of course.

What fruits have you got here?

As shopkeeper introduces goods, Dagyns lifts head spotting familiar shop behind fruit stall—the place he bought poison thirty years ago. He steps toward it.

Shop owner is a woman.

Vanessa

Greeting, my lord!

I'm Vanessa, my lord.

We don't stock much goods in this tiny shop.

Feel free to tell me what you need.

Just as Dagyns is about to speak, he claps hand over mouth abruptly and hurries back onto carriage.

Vanessa

What an odd nobleman, yet his face rings a bell somewhere.

CUT TO THE PEVERILL HOUSE - EVENING

INT. In the Dagyns's bedchamber

Dagyns (V.O.)

Another day passes, such an unusual day.

Though uncle repeatedly told me to maintain proper noble bearing outside home, human instinct never shows mercy.

Why did I make odd remarks to Nodde's daughter today?

I behaved like some vulgar pervert.

Oh god.

Edwin knocks and enters mid inner monologue.

Dagyns

What's wrong with, Edwin?

Edwin

My dear lord, here is warm milk.

It will help you fall asleep.

And Karin wants to say good night to you.

Karin

My Lord, may peaceful dreams grace your rest this night.

I bid you my sincerest goodnight.

Dagyns

Thank, my lovely Karin

And good night to you.

Edwin

Please retire early tonight, for you have a meeting with Viscount Thomas and the others tomorrow.

Dagyns

Edwin, I'll head to bed right after I finish this.

You take Karin outside first, if you please.

Edwin

Sure, my lord.

Karin, come.

Call for me or Karin should you need anything.

Karin

(nods respectfully, soft-spoken)

We shall attend nearby without delay, my Lord.

Rest easy.

Edwin and Karin exit bedroom, Dagyns keeps writing diary.

Dagyns (V.O.)

I keep dreaming of my uncle every single night these days, though I cannot fathom why.

Speaking of him, I constantly find myself wanting to... wanting to speak my mind... I fear I can hold out no longer.

Dagyns puts down pen, gas lamp glow covers his face.

Dagyns

(mutters)

Perhaps I need a sound night's sleep.

He turns off gas lamp, undresses and falls asleep instantly.

CUT TO:

(DREAM SEQUENCE)

The room shifts between weird red-black lights, mixed flashes of blue and dark brown.

Dagyns stumbles to bed with taupe bed sheet and sits down, dark taupe curtain hangs behind him.

Camera shoots upward from near his feet toward his chin. Two naked women emerge from sides whispering softly.

Two Strange naked women

(Naked woman: soft honeyed seductive whisper)

Say it.....

Say it.....

Say it.....

You can't resist anymore, you can't....

The two women melt into taupe curtain fabric, curtain blends taupe, pale blue and faint yellow.

Uncle's face emerges faintly from tinted curtain light.

Alistair's voice echoes indistinctly.

Dagyns

(VOICE DISTANT, DRIFTING, UNMOORED)

Uncle.....

Is.....

That.....

You.....

Alistair

(Uncle's voice: Low Sustained Tone)

Dagyns.....

Resist.....

Remember.....

Dagyns

(VOICE DISTANT, DRIFTING, UNMOORED)

Human Instinct.....

Can't.....

Resist.....

Can't.....

Refuse.....

Face.....

Uncle's face fades away little by little until gone entirely, all the while murmuring "Resist".

Two naked women step out from behind curtain, pale yellow light wraps Dagyns's face growing brighter, taupe and pale blue fade gradually.

One woman hugs his neck, another sits on his lap caressing his

cheek.

Two Strange naked women

(soft honeyed seductive whisper)

Say it.....

Say it.....

Can't.....

Resist.....

Spill.....

Out.....

Say.....

Is.....

Your.....

Nature.....

The lap-sitting woman creeps to floor, the neck-hugging one
crawls across bed, they take turns switching positions circling
him while repeating whispers.

Two Strange naked women

(soft honeyed seductive whisper)

Dagyns.....

Say.....

Nature.....

Say.....

Dagyns's lower face glows bright mustard yellow in dream, he
stays blank-faced staring forward.

Real-world Dagyns wakes abruptly, jumps out bed and runs out mansion.

Two naked women wrap in glowing yellow curtain dance around dazed Dagyns, curtain cloth partially covering their bodies sometimes brushing his face.

Dream scene overlaps real running shot; camera alternates between dancing women and wide-eyed Dagyns's face, frame flickers faster and faster until yellow curtain drifts across screen to blackout.

CU TO THE FRONT OF PEVERILL HOUSE

EXT. The path front of Peverill house - morning 5 a.m.

Mansion takes one-third frame width, rest of frame is roadside ground.

A sudden shout is heard from someone in the scene.

Dagyns

Candle!!!!!!!!!!

Camera cuts close on him yelling repeatedly.

Dagyns

Position!!!!!!!!!!

After brief pause he shouts again.

Dagyns

Murder it's me!!!!!!!!!!

Dagyns

I kill my uncle!!!!!!!

Dagyns

It's my fault!!!!!!!!!!!!

Dagyns

That candle!!!!!!!

Dagyns

I poisoned that candle!

Dagyns

I did it!!!!!!!!!!!!

He repeats shouting.

Dagyns

Candle!!!!!!!

Dagyns

Positions!!!!!!!!!!!!

Dagyns

I kill a man!!!!!!

Dagyns

He was my uncle!!!!

Neighbours and servants peek out doors, dawn dim light stops them recognising the earl, they go back indoors quickly. Edwin rubs sleepy eyes and glances out gate.

Edwin

What a crazy bug!

I hope the Earl hasn't been woken.

I shall return to my bed now. (yawns softly)

CUT TO THE MORNING FRONT THE PATH OF PEVERILL HOUSE

EXT. Front of the Peverill House' s door

Several Scotland Yard policemen confront Edwin who opens front door.

Edwin

(sharp and disdainful)

How uncouth you are, lacking all refinement.

The Earl is not someone you may call upon at will!

Leading officer is Duke Stewart's son Inspector George.

George

Sir, we are merely doing our duty.

Edwin

Oh, I know you.

The VI Duke Stewart.

Is this the bearing of a nobleman!

Did your father teach you to speak to your elders in such a manner?

Look at the state of you.

George

Sir, this has nothing to do with rank. We received a report.

Someone publicly confessed to murder in the street, reported by a neighbouring housemaid.

One witness believes it was Earl Peverell. We've come only to verify the matter.

Is he in residence?

Edwin

WHAT!?

How dare you are!

The incident was reported indeed, yet it could never have been my master.

He was abed at the time.

George

Sir, what proof do you have of that?

Edwin

What?

If you bear any personal grudge against His Lordship, direct your grievances at me instead.

George

Sir, as I have stated, this has nothing to do with station.

We are simply discharging our official duty.

James!

Take the men inside at once.

Edwin steps aside helplessly.

Edwin

Good heavens, the world has gone mad and turned savage.

Nobility is no longer held in any regard...

INT. In the Dagyns's bedchamber

James enters first followed by other officers, James scans room then turns to George.

James

Sir.....

George

My Lord, I regret to inform you that you must come with us.

Camera slowly pans to Dagyns with messy hair sitting by desk, speaking quietly to inspector.

Dagyns

(Voice Tightly)

George.....

CUT TO NOW - SCOTLAND YARD

INT. Underground Cells - DAY

Dagyns rests both hands-on tabletops.

Dagyns

Is that all thing.

(amused, brows arched)

Mr. Gregory, why the look of disbelief?

Every word I speak is the truth.

Gregory

Oh, dear, boy.....

I suspect dark fiendry is at work here.

We may need to send for a priest....

Dagyns

Gregory, Gregory, Gregory.....

I say there are no devils in this world.

Men invent demons as a convenient cloak for their own deeds.

It is an inescapable human instinct—and you are no exception, Mr. Gregory!

Gregory

Did your uncle ever mention whether such afflictions have run in your family before?

Dagyns

Well, you've hit upon the very crux of the matter.

Yet let me make one thing clear first: aberrance is inherent to human nature, and devils do not exist in this world.

Gregory

But you just said....

Dagyns

(said suddenly in a loud voice)

Mr. Gregory, have you ever had nightmares?

Gregory

Sure, everyone has nightmares.

It happens when something upsetting comes up or when you're under too much pressure.

What are you trying to say.....?

Dagyns

Then do you know where the word 'devil' comes from?

People have nightmares, so they turn these terrifying visions

into tangible beings, giving birth to the term.

Perhaps they simply dare not face their own innate physical instincts, dismissing such things as flaws or monstrosities.

In truth, humans are multifaceted creatures, yet they have yet to realize it.

Do you remember what I said about my mother earlier, Mr. Gregory?

Gregory

Sure, you say she was killed by devil.....

Gregory suddenly falls silent and stares floor as realization hits.

Dagyns

(Smiling faintly)

My dear Mr. Gregory, I told you there are no such things as devils at all.

All that exists is humanity's nature instincts.

Gregory

Then, what....

Dagyns

Well, I was utterly shocked when I sorted through my uncle's belongings.

One day, while sorting out documents in his drawer, I found my father's diary.

It was not until then that I understood.....

George pushes cell door open abruptly.

George

Mr. Gregory, we need to hurry.

Time is running out.

And the information checks out.

We've spoken to Vanessa, the Marketplace vendor, who confirmed her father sold an odorless poison to Master Dagyns twenty years ago.

George shut the door and left.

Right after that, Gregory stared at the direction George had gone in disbelief before slowly turning his head toward Dagyns.

Dagyns

Mr. Gregory, where were we just now?

.....

I think it's my father

Or say it's my father's brother.

Gregory

What do you mean that?

Dagyns

I kept spotting the line "I can't hold it in any longer; I have to speak out" whenever I went through his diary.

Curious, I flipped back through earlier pages, and the truth was more than I could bear.

I'd always taken it for granted that the man I called Dad was my biological father.

Never did I expect, after reading the diary, that the father I'd known all these years was actually my birth father's identical twin brother!

Gregory

Dear.....

Dagyns

He murdered my birth father while my mother was pregnant with me, driven solely by jealousy and his obsession to have her for himself.

Since my uncle looked virtually identical to my real father, Mom died believing the man beside her had always been her husband!

Gregory

It's...

Dagyns

Mr. Gregory, you may wonder how my father's brother's seemingly flawless crime was uncovered.

The answer is the perversity!

Many noble ladies in the neighborhood claimed my mother had been slain by a devil.

But as I've said before, there are no such things as evil spirits at work—everything stems from human nature and primitive instincts.

That morning, out of the blue, my uncle blurted out that he'd murdered his own brother merely to satisfy his selfish desires.

My mother and I were confused, thinking he was just overwhelmed by stress, so she stepped forward to calm him down.

In a sudden flurry, he shoved her accidentally, and the back of her head struck the sharp edge of the table.

Terrified, I hid inside a cabinet.

From my hiding spot, I listened as my fake father kept muttering incomprehensibly, behaving as if possessed by a demon.

I didn't dare emerge until patrolling soldiers arrived.

Dagyns grows agitated mid-speech then continues.

Dagyns

After reading the diary, everything clicks into place.

Now I understand why that fake father sat murmuring by the table after killing my mother.

He could no longer contain his secret and had to spill everything, knowing full well what he'd done was wrong.

Still, he just couldn't hold it in.

Dear Mr. Gregory, I'm the same as him.

I can't hold myself either!

Do you think I haven't tried to hold back?

But I'm only human! Mr. Gregory.

Why must I deny these primal physical instincts within me?

Dagyns stretches hand out cell bars grabbing Gregory's wrist tightly, Gregory leans backward scared.

Dagyns

Mr. Gregory, now you see why my uncle held me like that, don't

you?!

Who could possibly bear such a truth?

Still, I admire my uncle.

He managed to suppress his primal urges and never breathed a word of it.

Gregory's head tilts further back staring cell doorway screaming.

Gregory

George! George! George!

George rushes in with officers to pull two apart, turns to Gregory.

George

Thank you for your trouble, Mr. Gregory.

We'll take care of everything from here.

Please step outside first.

Gregory

Thank you, George.

Gregory stands up walking dejectedly toward exit.

Right before opening door Dagyns shouts.

Dagyns

Mr. Gregory!

Remember!

You can't resist!

Gregory freezes briefly then hurries out door.

Camera shifts to Dagyns sneering at George.

Dagyns

Oh, poor George.

You were raised as nobility and once clung to your father's old aristocratic upbringing.

Look at you now, HAHAAAAHA.

Deep down, this is what you've always longed for, dear George, as well as those hazy feelings for the opposite sex.

George

Shut up, you ugly monster!

Dagyns

HAHAHAHAHA!

This is what you've been dying to say all along, isn't it?

You couldn't hold out any longer either!

George stares at him shocked and furious, frame fades out gradually.

CUT TO THE FRONT OF Scotland Yard' S GATE

EXT. Front of the gate - Time is close to the noon

Gregory stands outside station staring a letter signed by his daughter.

After short thinking he folds letter into coat pocket and mutters.

Gregory

I probably,

(sigh)

can't resist.....

He turns and walks nervously into crowd on right side of gate.....

END.

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